

Case study 1: New teacher with non-binary gender identity in primary school

Initial situation

A 32-year-old non-binary teacher takes over a second grade class at a primary school at the beginning of the school year. The previous teacher, who was very popular with the children and parents, is taking a long-term leave of absence due to illness. The new teacher is empathetic, supportive, and professional. The children are curious and happy to have a new teacher. Already in the first week, they spontaneously ask personal questions, such as why the teacher has short hair or why she wears a pantsuit as a woman.

The children's perception

The children show great interest in the new teacher and quickly build a trusting relationship with her. The teacher responds to their questions in an open and age-appropriate manner, but repeatedly emphasizes that there are different ways of dressing and living and that everyone is allowed to be who they are. Although the children are curious about the teacher's differences, which are noticeable to them, they do not dwell on the person's gender identity.

Parents' concerns

After a few weeks, several parents contact the school administration. They emphasize their fundamental openness to the topic of gender diversity, but express concern that their children may be influenced by the presence and manner of communication of the new teacher. They also say that the children are already stressed by the departure of their previous class teacher and the associated changes. In particular, they are concerned that their children could be "unsettled in their own development" or even "steered in this direction" by their encounter with the non-binary teacher, especially as the topic is currently very present in the media.

Challenge for the school management and the team

The school management is faced with the task of taking the parents' concerns seriously while supporting the teacher's professional and respectful attitude. It is also important to protect the interests of the children and their right to diversity and education without alienating the parents.

Possible discussion points for CAS participants

- How can contact with parents be structured constructively?

- What arguments and information could help parents put their fears into perspective?
- How does the school support the new teacher professionally and communicatively?
- What measures could contribute to promoting an open and inclusive climate in the long term in school and parent work?
- How do participants deal with this case from their own professional perspective (e.g. education, psychology, school social work, law, human resources, management)?

Establishing constructive contact with parents

- Appreciative dialogue: Invite parents to a personal meeting and actively listen to their concerns without rushing to judgment.
- Transparency and information: Inform parents in a factual and understandable way about how the teacher talks to the children about diversity in an age-appropriate and neutral manner.
- Focus on the well-being of the children: Emphasize together that everyone is working toward the same goal—the emotional and academic well-being of the children.
- Involve mediation and school social work: If dialogue is difficult, bring in neutral professionals (e.g. school social workers, external mediators).

Arguments and information to put fears into perspective

- Age-appropriate education does not influence children: Children primarily see their new teacher as a trusted adult, not as a “role model for sexual or gender orientation.”
- Visibility of diversity strengthens resilience: Encountering diversity helps children understand their own and other ways of life and develop empathy.
- Professional mandate of the teacher: The teacher follows the curriculum and the school’s mandate on equal opportunities and non-discrimination.
- Encourage media reflection: Point out to parents that children are confronted with these issues through the media anyway – conscious and guided engagement with them at school is more constructive than picking up information without reflection.

Provide professional and communicative support to the new teacher

- Clear positioning of the school management: The management emphasizes its support for the teacher and the values of the school (diversity, tolerance, professionalism).
- Offer supervision or coaching: Give the teacher the opportunity to reflect on their experiences and strengthen their communication strategies.
- Collegial support: Discuss the new challenges within the teaching staff and establish common standards for communication with parents.

Measures to promote an inclusive school climate

- Theme evenings for parents on diversity, education, and prevention of discrimination (with external experts if necessary).
- Workshops or projects with children on diversity, respect, and mutual appreciation.
- Internal training on gender-sensitive language and professional handling of diversity.
- Provide transparent communication materials (e.g. letters to parents, FAQs on school values).

Include expert perspectives

- Pedagogical: Emphasize the promotion of children's identity formation and class community.
- Psychological: Show parents that contact with diversity does not destabilize children's development but rather strengthens their social skills.
- School social work: Offer parents and children low-threshold opportunities for discussion.
- Legal: Point out the prohibition of discrimination under school law and the school's duty to provide information and ensure equal treatment.
- Management level: Take a clear stance and inform all those involved transparently about procedures and decisions.